



Soldiers of US 7th Armored Division patrol the snowy Belgian town of St. Vith, a site of fierce fighting during the German Ardennes offensive in December.

As the Germans withdrew, the celebrations in Paris began, and so too did **reprisals against alleged collaborators**. Around 9,000 French people were summarily executed and tens

Liberation of Paris

Parisians celebrate the liberation of their city, and welcome the return of General de Gaulle to France as leader of the Free French.



of thousands subjected to public humiliation—for example, women were paraded with shaved heads—before **De Gaulle formed a provisional government** and restored order.

At the beginning of August the **Polish resistance movement** staged an uprising against the Germans in Warsaw. The Soviet Red Army had almost reached the city, after pushing westward through the summer, but Stalin had no desire to help the Poles, who were mostly anti-Russian and anticommunist. The Red Army stopped short of Warsaw, and did little for two months while the Polish uprising was crushed by Nazi troops. Several hundred thousand Poles were killed. After the survivors surrendered in early October, the Germans destroyed Warsaw.

In the west in September, with the Allies in control of most of Belgium, British general Bernard Montgomery (1887–1976) devised a plan to end the war quickly by an **airborne invasion of the occupied Netherlands**. British, US, and Polish paratroopers attempted to seize and hold a series of bridges that would allow Allied tanks to advance into northern Germany. The last bridge at **Arnhem** was not taken, however, and the operation failed leaving the Netherlands to suffer a harsh winter under the Nazis.

The US **offensive in the Pacific** gathered momentum through the year (see pp.394–95). Outnumbered and militarily outclassed, the Japanese fought with suicidal

determination. In the battle for the **island of Saipan** between June 15 and July 9, almost the entire garrison of 30,000 Japanese soldiers were killed. The Japanese Imperial Navy was almost wiped out in two great battles—the **Philippine Sea** in June, and **Leyte Gulf** in October.

Facing near certain death in unequal combat with superior US forces, some Japanese naval pilots mounted “**kamikaze**” suicide attacks, deliberately crashing their aircraft into US warships. These tactics proved



Prayer for safety

For good luck, some Japanese servicemen carried their national flag with a special prayer written on it, asking for a safe return.

so effective that they were adopted as a form of mass attack, using hundreds of virtually untrained rookie pilots.

Facing defeat in Europe, Hitler put his faith in secret weapons. The first jet aircraft, the German **Messerschmitt 262**, entered the conflict, but failed to reverse the

“... AN OPERATION OF THE MOST EXTREME DARING.”

General Alfred Jodl, Chief of Operations on Hitler's counteroffensive



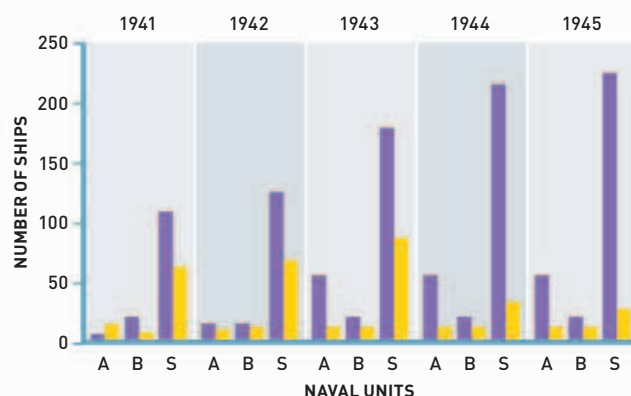
Flying bomb

The German unmanned V-1 flying bomb was propelled by a primitive jet engine and packed with explosives. In summer 1944 more than 100 a day were fired at London.

mounting dominance of Allied air forces. The **V1 flying bombs** launched against London caused heavy casualties, but had no decisive effect, nor did the **V2 rockets**, the world's first ballistic missiles. Around 3,000 V2s were launched, mostly at London and Antwerp. They arrived without warning and there was no defense against them, but they were inaccurate, and failed to have the impact Hitler desired.

In December, the German Führer made his last gamble with a surprise offensive in the

Ardennes, which became known as the **Battle of the Bulge**. German tanks broke through the US front line and headed for Antwerp. Stiffening resistance, especially by US airborne troops at Bastogne, was followed by a well-organized Allied counter-attack. The German tanks ran out of fuel, and improved weather allowed Allied aircraft to strike in support of ground forces. Hitler's last throw of the dice had failed.



US and Japanese naval strengths

A combination of vastly productive US shipyards and heavy Japanese losses enabled the US to win naval dominance in the Pacific.

KEY
 ■ US
 ■ Japan
 A Aircraft carriers
 B Battleships
 S Submarines

